
A First Trip

Plan for catching, not for fishing

How to take somebody fishing who has never been

The failure mode of a first trip is always the same: an adult who wants to catch a good fish takes a beginner to a place where good fish live, and the beginner spends four hours not catching anything and concludes that fishing is boring. They are right. Plan the opposite trip.

The plan

Target bluegill	Not bass, not walleye, not "whatever bites". In June a bluegill bed will produce a fish every few minutes, and constant action is the entire point. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Go in June	Late May through June, when panfish are on the beds in 1–4 ft of water and you can see them. Pine Lake spot 6 ; North Lake spot 1 .
Go in the evening	Two hours before dark, not eight in the morning. Warmer, calmer, better bite, and a natural end to the trip.
Keep it short	Ninety minutes. Leave while it is still fun. The trip should end because you decided to end it, not because somebody has stopped enjoying it.
One rod each	A short spinning rod, 4 lb line, a fixed bobber a couple of feet above a size 8 hook, half a worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i> — but use a fixed float, not a slip float, for the first trip.
Pinch the barbs	Flatten every barb with pliers. You will lose a few fish and you will save yourself the one memory that ends the hobby: a barbed hook in a finger, an hour from the car.

What to bring

- Rod, already rigged, at home
- A spare rod, also already rigged
- Worms, more than you think
- Long-nose pliers
- Nail clippers for line
- Landing net
- Wet towel
- Life jackets that fit *them*
- Sunscreen and a hat
- Bug spray
- Snacks and water — more than the fishing gear, honestly
- Something to keep fish in, if keeping
- A first-aid kit with tweezers

The first hour, in order

1. **Rig everything at home.** Not at the water, not in the wind, not while somebody is waiting. Arrive ready to cast.
2. **Life jackets on before the boat.** No discussion, and the adult wears one too — they will do what you do, not what you say.
3. **Five minutes on casting, on grass, before you leave.** A weight and no hook. Underhand flip, not overhead. It removes the largest source of frustration on the water.
4. **Anchor on the bed and stay put.** Do not run around looking for better. Better is worse.
5. **Let them do everything they can.** Bait the hook badly, cast badly, reel too fast. Your job is to untangle things and say very little.
6. **Show them the first fish properly.** Wet hands, look at the gill flap, name it, count the spines, let them hold it, put it back. *see the **Handling & Release** sheet*
7. **Leave on a fish.** When the bite is still good and they are still laughing, that is the moment to go.

Things that go wrong, and the fix

Problem	Fix
Tangles	Inevitable. Carry the pre-rigged spare rod, hand it over, and untangle the first one later. Do not make a child stand and watch you pick at a bird's nest for ten minutes.
Nothing biting	You are in the wrong spot or too deep. Move shallower, go smaller, use less bait. Half a worm out-fishes a whole one for panfish every time.
Bored	The bite has slowed. Change activity rather than persisting: look at what is in the water, catch a crayfish under a rock, throw the cast net, go home. Fishing is not the only good thing about being at a lake.
Hook in a finger	This is why the barbs are pinched. Back it out the way it went in, clean it, plaster on it, carry on. With a barb still on, cut the line and see a doctor.
Frightened of the fish	Normal. Hold it yourself first, let them touch it while you hold it, and do not push. They will pick one up within a couple of trips.

The measure of success

Not the size of the fish, and not how many. The measure is whether they ask to go again. Everything on this sheet is arranged to make that answer yes.

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